

Honourable JUSTICE

A landmark decision sentences five persons to death in a case of honour killing



MANOJ
AND BABLI

By Arvind Chhabra

At 2.30 p.m. on March 30, a posse of policemen escorted seven men, all attired identically in white so typical of rural Haryana, into courtroom number 10 on the first floor of the Karnal District Courts. Almost an hour later, Additional District and Sessions Judge Vani Gopal Sharma entered the packed courtroom to announce the sentence to the seven who had, a week earlier, been held guilty of brutally murdering a young couple who got married in defiance of the panchayat. There was no sign of remorse on their faces as the judge announced their fate: five of the seven were sentenced to death, one was awarded life imprisonment and the last got away rather lightly with a seven-year jail

term. As they were escorted back to the jail, they waved defiantly at a handful of relatives and supporters.

"This is a historic decision that is expected to bring to an end the diktats of khap panchayats. So far they had no fear as political bosses refrained from acting against them. With this verdict, those who try to impose a medieval order on society will think twice," says Surat Singh, director Haryana Institute of Rural Development, Nilokheri. "They have been running a parallel government issuing '*tuglaqi farmaans*' off and on. Now they know whose writ runs in this democratic country," says Lal Bahadur Khawal, advocate for the family of Manoj (23), who along with his newly wedded wife Babli (19), was killed on the orders of the khap panchayat in just over two months after their wedding in April

Gory Trail

6 April, 2007: Manoj and Babli elope from Karoran, Kaithal

7 April: They marry in a temple at Chandigarh

6 June: Threatened, they seek police protection

15 June: Manoj calls family for the last time

23 June: Bodies found in a canal near Narnaund

24 June: Cremated by the police as unclaimed

25 March, 2010: 6 convicted for murder, 1 for kidnapping

30 March: Sentences pronounced by the court